

which was awesome. During the cocktail hour, my job was to walk around with a tray and offer people appetizers like mushroom tarts and salmon rolls. Sometimes I manned the fruit and vegetable bar.

Every weekend we worked from 6:00 p.m. to early in the a.m. when we had to clean up the whole affair. Sometimes that required mopping up vomit from the bathroom. Sometimes it was just breaking down tables and cleaning up garbage from the dance floor (including drunk Uncle Fred!). I was paid in cash. I don't remember what my salary was, just that it was enough for me to cover whatever expenses I had as a high schooler. (Spiked chokers and black eyeliner?) I didn't save anything from that job.

I worked there for a year and was eventually let go because I kept eating the food. I would give out an appetizer and then sneak one into my mouth. Eventually someone from a wedding party noticed me doing this and rightfully complained. I was not a good catering waiter.

I was, however, a good writer. When I was 16, I got into a paid internship program at the local newspaper. I was so happy because (1) I needed a job and (2) it was actually in the field I hoped to go into. How many teenagers can say that? The program was called Next Gen, and it became one of the most consistent and treasured aspects of my high school experience. We got to attend editorial meetings at the newspaper offices, pitch our own stories, and write little articles that actually appeared in the paper with our bylines. I wrote about all sorts of topics: music reviews, profiles of Christian rock bands, ROTC champions and robotics clubs, and tips on how to decorate your locker.

When I was a senior in high school, I graduated to a job at the neighborhood division of the paper based out of a city called Tamarac. I was officially a freelance reporter there, no longer merely a teen intern. I'd go in, get assignments, write them either before school (so at 6:00 a.m.) or after school and then they'd run in the newspaper. I was paid by the source, so for every person I interviewed, I got more money. This led to 500-word stories with seven sources. I wanted to get PAID.

Because I was still in school, I sometimes worked during class too. I often omitted my age when interviewing people. Sources, not knowing I was a high school student, would call me on my cell phone during the day for interviews.